

Killer Rigs

If you're looking to assemble a PC for yourself or someone else, we have you covered. Seriously.

What's necessary

- **802.11ac for faster Wi-Fi** – it's the latest wireless data transfer standard. Everything else is sloooooow!
- **Fast hard drive** – if you're getting an SSD machine, just go for it!
- **Lots of battery life** – remember, you can never have enough battery life.
- **Good feature set** – ensure your laptop has the basic connectivity options like USB 3.0 ports, Gigabit Ethernet, Bluetooth, SD card slot, etc. Nothing obvious should be missing.

What's not

- **Fastest GPU** – Why would you want to get a blazingly fast GPU on your business machine? Makes no sense. No sense at all.
- **Lots of storage** – Seriously, you don't need lots of storage. Just enough. Look for SSDs, faster access times is always better than more space.
- **Speakers** – Don't have high expectations of your laptop's built-in speakers, because they aren't meant to be very good in the first place.

one year limited warranty, just like most traditional consumer laptops sold in the market. However, business laptops have more flexible warranty upgrade options that ties in with after sales support – both of these things are very important from the point of view of safeguarding your investment in the future.

After sales support is configurable while purchasing your machine, depending on what your requirement is. If you can't afford your machine to be down for long, most brands in this space offer same day pickup and delivery of the device (after successful resolution of the issue) faster than general support terms. So do give this part of your laptop buying process a thorough read through before deciding what's best for you and ultimately purchasing the business laptop that you need.

Having considered all of these points, here are a few recommended business laptops based on my personal experience: Toshiba Portege Z30t-A or HP Elitebook 1040 G1 for a business ultrabook, Lenovo ThinkPad S1 YOGA for a hybrid notebook. Lenovo ThinkPad W540, Dell Precision M3800 or HP ZBook 15 are very good mobile workstation laptops to consider. For mid-ranged business notebooks, consider the Dell Vostro 14 3446, HP ProBook 640G1, or Acer Travelmate P645. 

ENTER THE WORLD OF VIDEO GAMES!

For the last seven years of my 33-year long career, I have been teaching Communications Studies at a School of Video Gaming. I teach a five-year series of modules I have evolved to ensure that our students graduate with top-of-the-line communication skills that are perfectly in tune with the exacting industry they plan to enter.

Anxious parents, whose children plan to storm the field of video gaming as game designers / game artists / programmers, often ask me "How shall we get him/her prepared to face the curriculum?" In this article, I shall try to respond to exactly this question.

Both positions (designers and artists) in any creative team must bring an immense wealth of background material, readings, knowledge, skills, and curiosity in a wide variety of fields. If video games are to rise above the ordinary in their gameplay, then they must appeal to their audience by being "different"! This "difference", believe it or not, is to come from the collective creativity of the team fed on a steady diet of books, films, games, histories, fantasies, etc.

The average Indian curriculum leading to the 12th Standard Higher Secondary Certificate makes no heavy demands upon a candidate's reading skills. Watered-down versions (or "retold" stories) form the bulk of the reading list, which usually receives short shrift from impatient college lecturers hired on the ubiquitous CHB (Clock

Hour basis)! A wide variety of "guides" and "notes" feed students the material that will be "regurgitated" onto the answer paper during the examination. And so, it is quite possible that the average 12th Standard student can "pass" his examination without ever facing any of the classics of World Literature in the original at all!

This, then, is the first lacuna that students desiring to study Video Game Design, Art or Programming must fill on their own. They must read as much as they can, familiarise themselves with subjects as diverse as Geography and History, Sciences and the History of Sciences. They must have, in a word, what my generation studied as 'General Knowledge' before State Governments in India stepped in to dilute the academic offering in schools across the country! And the "syllabus" for that subject, unfortunately, cannot be exactly described.

The means are varied, the objective must remain steady! Our youngsters must be better equipped to enter the world of video game creation. For it is only then that they shall be able to push the frontiers of their chosen field further and forward.

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Read or you won't be able to game